

Postmaster

Good and bad

Like the others, Postmaster has a simple installation procedure. It has a single-step configuration wizard that asks for the domain name, POP3 settings for the external mail server and the external SMTP server.

Barring the first START/STOP button, the text on the rest of the buttons on the Console page is unreadable.

A good feature is the remote dialler, which, in the presence of settings such as time-based and queue scheduling, does an exceedingly good job. While time-based scheduling is quite common, the queue-based feature lets you specify the number of e-mails in the queue, after which the dialler dials out and forwards the messages to the external SMTP server.

The maximum size restriction can be different for incoming and outgoing mails. In the case of outgoing mails, those sent on a local network can have an unlimited size, while the rest can be filtered to a user-defined maximum size.

Postmaster bundles along an anti-virus and an anti-spam solution. On the security front, it screens hosts based on IP addresses, and not on hostnames. It lacks SSL support and a feature to create mailing lists.

This software can also act as a proxy server for the local network, thus eliminating the need for a third-party proxy server.

A negative, though: at times, you do not know what's happening in the software. The logs are not updated immediately, which may lead you to assume that the software is not functioning. In such a situation, the monitor can be helpful. However, finding it is another hassle, since the button that opens its window has unreadable text. By default, logging is disabled for most of the operations. You'll have to browse through the different sections and enable logging where needed.

Features-wise, Postmaster has nothing much to crow about. Its performance too was lacklustre. However, a point to be noted is that Postmaster has an extensive local network of distributors. This though is a small thing in its favour.

Price: Rs 4,500 (six users)
Web site: <http://postmaster.co.in/>

- + Remote dialler
- Lacks screening based on host names; button text unreadable



The console screen for Postmaster shows what the server's been doing

Postmaster	B+
Performance	4 out of 5 stars
Features	4 out of 5 stars
Ease of use	4 out of 5 stars

qmail

Linux's Mr Popular

You need lots of patience to install qmail and get it to work, even though there's a lot of online help to assist you. One such Web site is <http://lifewithqmail.org>. qmail is commonly used with Linux, and most system administrators managing Linux servers are sure to have worked with qmail at some point.

Changing Hosts

A word of caution: Changing the Hosting Service Provider (HSP) takes around 48 hours or more. While this happens, you might not be able to receive e-mails or access them. Relax! This is normal. You might even lose some messages during the process. Therefore, don't change your service provider frequently. Make that decision once and for all. However, if at all you ever need to switch providers, prepare yourself in advance for the oncoming trouble.

It can't download POP3 messages from an external mail server automatically, nor can it auto-sort mailboxes. It lacks a remote dialler as well. Additionally, you'll need to configure a program—fetchmail—to be able to download messages, since qmail lacks this functionality. However, features such as auto-reply, user-wise quota, a Web-based interface, anti-virus, anti-spam, SMTP authentication and POP3-before-SMTP that are not present by default can be installed for free, with downloadable patches.

Its biggest advantage is that it's free, and light—it comprises just a POP3 and SMTP server. The functionalities needed for today's mail server can be added with the help of third-party patches that you can download from Web sites such as <http://qmail.org>.

Price: Free
Web site: <http://qmail.org>

- + Lots of free add-ons and documentation
- Lacks many inbuilt features; installation tests your patience

qmail	B+
Performance	4 out of 5 stars
Features	4 out of 5 stars
Ease of use	4 out of 5 stars

Conclusion

Despite the uncertainty in the testing environment, the average download speed was in the range of 36 Kbps to 39 Kbps. Performance-wise, the speed test saw values ranging from 33 minutes to 37 minutes while downloading messages that were nearly 11 MB in size, which was more or less similar across the board.

In the virus test, only Merak Mail showed positive results, detecting 14 out of the 22 virus messages. Others either did not have integrated anti-virus support, or weren't able to detect them.

These software accepted all messages in the flood test, but over varying time frames. IMail and Office Mail accepted all of them at one go, though IMail was a bit faster. Following them were Merak Mail (991), MDAemon (696) and PostMaster (337). The bracketed values indicate the messages accepted in a single stretch, after which they deferred the newer connection for some time.

A cost-effective solution would naturally be free software! Examples are Office Mail, qmail, IMail (for 10 users) and Surge-Mail (for 5 users). If your system administrator can handle a Linux server, there's nothing like qmail—lots of goodies for free! However, it takes ages to install and configure. Windows users should opt for Office Mail, which is simple, easy to configure and very light on system resources.

Finally, we had a few good performers—CommuniGate Pro, MDAemon, PostMaster, Kerio Mail and Merak Mail—that catered to the vast majority that uses a dial-up connection. The race was closely competed, but eventually, only MDAemon and Merak Mail came out with a 100 per cent score in the features section. Choosing between these two was difficult—even the 'Ease of Use' factor was unable to bring up a winner.

Ultimately, it was the virus test that gave Merak Mail the edge over MDAemon, and our recommendation award.